Two Rooms

By Lee Blessing

LAINIE: **(Pg 16)** *(an empty room, she is clearly seeing a different time and place)* A hotel in Beirut near where we lived was destroyed in some shelling a couple of months before . . . before he was taken. *(beat)* **(Pg 8-9)** I'm talking to myself. All last night, taking the furniture out of this room, I was talking to myself. For the last year, what else have I been doing? Talking to everyone in power – which is, of course, the definition of talking to yourself. The Arabs wouldn't help me, but at least they'd resect the pain. In Washington, I ***was*** the pain. *(beat)* **(Pg 10)** The government's coming today. [Someone] attached to me. My case.

INTRODUCTION

*****According to the James Foley Foundation and recent White House Statements from President Joe Biden regarding American hostages in Gaza, as of January 14, 2024, nearly 70 U.S. nationals are known to be held hostage or wrongfully detained in at least 15 countries. *(update as needed)* Over 90% of these cases are wrongful detentions that interfere with U.S. foreign policy and national security. Of those hostages, six have been held for over 10 years.*

Written in 1990, this selection deals with a subject still very much in the minds of contemporary society – the taking of innocent hostages by political terrorists, the agony of the detainees and the helpless fury of those who are left behind – loved ones impatient for something to be done and officials who have a larger political agenda in mind.

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ELLEN: **(Pg 12-13)** The most important thing to remember is that we're not speaking of a country of terrorists here. We're barely speaking of a country at all. We're speaking of factions. Some friendly to Iran, some to Syria, some to Israel, some to us. They're all fighting for power. For all we know your husband -

LAINIE: Michael.

ELLEN: Michael may be liberated by a faction that favors us. The crucial thing – is knowing that hope is a real and present possibility.

LAINIE: What are the chances?

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ELLEN: There are pictures. We have pictures of Michael. Taken just a month ago. Pictures of him alive.

WALKER: He had the s*** beat out of him. He was barely recognizable. It's our Middle East policy that's keeping your husband hostage. Nothing else.

ELLEN: **(Pg 11)** What have we been talking about for the last year, Lanie? It's absurd for you to talk to newspapers. We have no way of knowing what public statements by hostage relatives may do. No way at all. It could make it harder for us to secure a safe return.

LAINIE: **(Pg 13)** When will my husband be released?

ELLEN: Lainie – this government is using every ethical means to bring your husband back to you. **(Pg 14)** There are however acts of God, for example, over which no government has power.

LAINIE: You think this is an act of God?

WALKER: **(Pg 13)** This government wouldn't care if your husband died. Because then he's not a problem anymore. Have you ever wondered why other governments can get their hostages out and we can't?

ELLEN: They pay ransom.

WALKER: And it works!

ELLEN: Either he goes – right now – or I do. *(beat)* Lainie? *(a glimpse of irritation crossing her face. She exits)*

WALKER: **(Pg 19)** You understand what's really going on.

LAINIE: What's really going on?

WALKER: What's really going on is that they'll let him die. They've already made the value judgment. To this administration, it's more effective to use his captivity – and even his death – to push a bunch of policy points, than it is to get him back.

LANIE: You really think that?

WALKER: I know it. So do you. The day he's reported dead, they'll be all over TV,

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pointing the finger at every terrorist in the Middle East, saying, "These are barbarians. Don't try to understand them, just let us do what we must." And we'll let them.

LAINIE: What do you think I should do?

WALKER: Speak out. Do interviews. Go on TV if you have to. *(beat)* **(Pg 20)** Care about your husband.

LAINIE. I ***do***!

WALKER: [Then] do something!

LAINIE: I ***am***! *(beat)* You know what will get him back? Nothing. Whatever took Michael, whatever will bring him back is a power so incomprehensible we'll never understand it. And all the running around screaming about injustice won't change a thing. All we can do – all anyone can do – is take pictures of mourning widows. Write stories about mourning widows. Become fascinated with widows of men who aren't even dead yet. But nothing – ***nothing*** – will make a difference.

WALKER: Lainie, I'm only . . .

LAINIE: Get out!

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MICHAEL: *(blindfolded and in handcuffs)* War isn't a tear in the fabric of things, it is the fabric. Americans fight all the time – lots of wars. But always far away. We haven't had to fight for the soil we stand on in a century. We've forgotten that level of sacrifice. These people haven't. Everyone in this country -- Christian, Palestinian, Israeli – everyone is fighting for the ground itself. They stand here or nowhere. It's easy for them to kill. Lanie, don't you see? We're not different from these people, we've just forgotten.

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ELLEN: **(Pg 28-29)** What does it mean to be an American? Well, here it means - for most of us – "to be comfortable." Elsewhere in the world it means to be punished

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for the crime of having been born here and not there. Enormous numbers of people all over the world hating Americans. Willing to kill even the most innocent of us. To imprison us without trial. For years. Why? They watch our television, you know. See our films, wear our clothes, drive our cars, listen to our music. They learn in our universities. What do they learn? That they have been born in a part of the world which has no power. [And so their] only reality is to reject and destroy what they can of the Western world.

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LAINIE: **(Pg 31- 33)** How's the crisis coming?

ELLEN: You should know. You're doing enough to intensify it.

LAINIE: That's not what I'm doing.

ELLEN: It isn't? Let me remind you of your phone call to me yesterday . . . *(mimics Lanie's words, perfectly)* "Walker says I should go on TV. I think he may be right. Maybe this is a real opportunity to put pressure on people."

LAINIE: I didn't mean you.

ELLEN: Of course you meant me. You meant the State Department.

LAINIE: All right, so I did mean you. So what?

ELLEN: Lainie, we have a lot of Americans trapped with some exceedingly dangerous terrorists in a very cramped charter terminal in Crete. If you start jumping onto TV screens now, God knows what effect it will have.

LAINIE: Can't we just wait them out? Can't we . . . ?

ELLEN: This group likes to die for what they believe in. They're not like a bunch of bank robbers. When terrorists take a group as large as this, everyone understand it's a short-term project.

LAINIE: Project? Is that how you see it? What's Michael – a ***long***-term project?

ELLEN: Sadly, in a sense, yes.

LAINIE: Because he wasn't lucky enough to be abducted in an airport? With a bunch of other people?

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ELLEN: If you go public, if you make demands, you'll only increase the danger for everyone involved. And frankly, no matter what you do, we won't ask for Michael's release. It's not his time.

LAINIE: His ***time***?

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MICHAEL: **(Pg 35)** LAINIE!! LAINIE!! *(beat, he removes his blindfold and looks around fearfully, then relaxes slightly)* They moved me again. They have a box they put me in – the shape of a coffin and it's soundproof. The first time they put the box in the back of a van with a bad exhaust system. I was unconscious when they took me out. (beat) Sometimes I don't know. I don't absolutely know whether I'm alive or dead.

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WALKER: **(Pg 36-37)** We did it! We got the message out! We put those bastards on the spot. They're going to have to ask for everybody – I know it! You were fantastic! Everybody in America felt for you. Was I right or what? The cameramen were tearing up.

LAINIE: They were not.

WALKER: I saw tears. Men who've seen every disgusting, pitiful atrocity that ever happened. But they cried tonight. For Michael. For you.

LAINIE: No one has to cry for me.

WALKER: They do. That's the point. That's the power. Every once in a while, enormous numbers of people become ready to hear something. And if you've got what they're ready to hear, then you're a very powerful person. You have to use it.

LAINIE: Is that all this has been? You've just been waiting for me to . . . blossom into some kind of spokesperson for you?

WALKER: Not for me . . . For Michael. How do you think you're going to get him back? ESP? You going to pray he'll show up? He won't You'll get him back when

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you make this government uncomfortable enough to lean on somebody – that's it.

LAINIE: I don't feel like celebrating. For all I know, I haven't done anything more than risk the lives of innocent people tonight.

WALKER: Look . . . I've waited a year for a story . . .

LAINIE: Michael's waiting. Not you. Not me. Michael! *(softly, near tears)* **(Pg 38-39)** I can't see him anymore. I can't remember what he looks like.

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MICHAEL: Sometimes I wake up and realize that months have gone by. (beat) Time is change. That's all it is. When there's no change. When there's no change . . . Yesterday one of my guards told me I'd been here three years. (beat) I didn't know what he meant. *(beat)* **(Pg 44-45)** Some clothes were thrown on me and I was hustled into the back seat of a car by three men. They drove me to a quiet neighborhood and shoved me into a building. I was taken down, still blindfolded, to a small, cramped room that smelled like . . . clay, and I was . . . *(pantomimes the execution gunshot) (long beat)*

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ELLEN: **(Pg 45-46)** When I worked in the Defense Department, I told them their men were heroes. I said, "He died of bad luck." No bad planning at the top, not tactical mistakes of his commanders. Bad luck. Lainie gets the truth. We miscalculated. We valued Michael's life below a chance to make an international point. We increased the danger for all the hostages. We chose to **(Pg 41-42)** intercept a terrorist. Not a Shi'ite, not even Lebanese. But an Arab, and . . . we killed him. It was the judgment of the Department that Michael and the others would not be overly . . . endangered. **(Pg 46)** We miscalculated.

LAINIE: Thank you.

ELLEN: *(turns with surprise)* Lainie, I . . . I wasn't ---

LAINIE: *(angry)* Going to say it like that? I'm glad you did. Is that all your business?

ELLEN: Allow me to take this opportunity to convey the deep sympathy of the

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Secretary of State and the President.

LAINIE: Go to hell. *(long beat)* **(Pg 47)** *(with heavy sarcasm turning to intense sadness)* No, I think you and the government did your best. I think everyone did his best. Michael, Walker, you, the Shi'ites – even the ones that killed Michael. Probably everyone has done his best. That's what frightens me. That's why I don't know if I'll ever be able to walk out of this room anymore. Into what? A world filled with people doing their best.

ELLEN: I wish I could take your pain away.

LAINIE: I wish you could remember it.

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**** Introduction source information***

The James w. Foley Legacy Foundation

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and

Statement from President Joe Biden Marking 100 Days of Captivity for Hostages in Gaza January 14, 2024.

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